

CHHAUNK
On Food, Economics and Society
By Abhijit Banerjee
Illustrated by Cheyenne Olivier
JUGGERNAUT
₹899; 352 pages

Indian and occidental food, so several recipes are engineered for that purpose." Perhaps the most outré example of this is the 'Millefeuille of Papad and Baigan Bharta', a savoury South Indian take on the classic French pastry. And, if you're wondering, each of the recipes in the book was cooked by Banerjee before it made the cut.

Banerjee is perhaps unusual among Indian men in having learned to cook early, helping his mother out in the kitchen as a child. "My mother was quite a vociferous feminist, so it was not exactly accidental," explains Banerjee. "You would get these long diatribes about lazy Indian males. My father, for example, made breakfast for us every day. He didn't want to push his luck!" Cooking also gave the young Banerjee an opportunity to spend time with his mother, a busy academic who also ran an NGO.

More than any particular dish, Banerjee remembers the ritual order of eating the dishes. "You'd get scolded for eating your fish before your *shukto*," he says. When pressed to name a favourite dish, he chooses two: *ilisher tel jhal* from his Bengali heritage and *khandvi*—or *suralichi vadi*, as the Maharashtrians call it—in a nod to his Marathi mother.

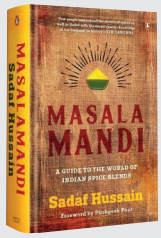
What sets Indian food apart, Banerjee feels "is our deep understanding of different flavouring agents". He, however, rues the fact that we are losing the culture of letting no part of an ingredient go to waste, what he calls "creativity driven by need". "For instance, in Bengal, you cook the potato, but also the potato skin with poppy seeds and chilli (*aloo khosha bhaja*)," he explains.

Chhaunk is also part memoir, brimming with interesting anecdotes, like Banerjee's brief incarceration in Tihar Jail during his student days in JNU or the time his great-great-grandfather gifted the dhoti he was wearing to a bringer of good news and went off in the buff. "Ultimately, for me, writing these columns is therapy. It allows me to revisit my childhood, my family, my many friends, my hopes and disappointments, and perhaps above all, the India that I love and never left," he says. ■

–Amit Dixit

MELTING POT

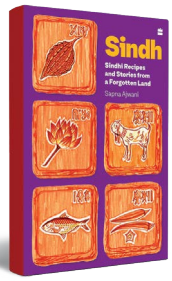
Delightful compendiums that showcase the breathtaking range of Indian food



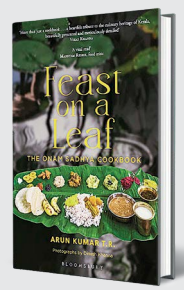
MASALAMANDI
A Guide to the World of Indian Spice Blends
By Sadaf Hussain
PENGUIN VIKING
₹999; 568 pages

Not only is Chef Sadaf Hussain's tour de force a treasure trove of spice mixes from across the length and breadth of India—from Khotachiwadi East Indian Bottle Masala to Madras Curry Powder, Mrs Beeton's Indian Curry Powder, masala chai spice blends and an array of chaat and garam masalas—there are recipes, too, for dishes where the spice mix is fundamental to their identity. These include biryanis, kababs, pickles, curries and more. Gourmands like Ranveer Brar and Pushpesh Pant, too, have generously shared their blends.

Sindhi cuisine has a vast repertoire beyond the famed kadhi, as the over 120 recipes—ranging from everyday food to festive fare—in this affectionately written cookbook attest. The author recalls having *loli ain baido* (crispy biscuit bread and fried eggs) for breakfast and Friday specials after school consisting of *daag mein teevan ain chawaran* (mutton stew with rice) or *seyal macchi* (onion and tamarind fish). Other delights include Karachi bun kebab, *khus khus jo jiro* (poppy seed halwa), and *kheeme ji tikki* (mincemeat patties). Yum!



SINDH
Sindhi Recipes and Stories from a Forgotten Land
By Sapna Ajwani
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
₹1,199; 272 pages



FEAST ON A LEAF
The Onam Sadhya Cookbook
By Arun Kumar T.R.
BLOOMSBURY INDIA
₹799; 208 pages

If you've ever been intimidated by the prospect of rustling up an Onam sadhya—the Malayali vegetarian festive feast served on a banana leaf which can feature up to 64 different dishes—fear no more. *Feast on a Leaf* is a step-by-step guide to earning your sadhya chops, educating you on traditional lore, the utensils used, different sadhya menus and, of course, recipes to the dishes themselves, from avial to olan, thoran to kaalan, and an impressive range of payasams. In keeping with modern dietary fashions, there's even help on how to put together a vegan, gluten-free sadhya.

–Amit Dixit